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I am a third-year Computer Science Ph.D. student at EPFL supervised by Antoine Bosselut (EPFL) and Lonneke van der Plas (Università della Svizzera italiana). My research interests broadly lie in the nature of robust artificial intelligence, language and creativity. Currently, my research focuses on understanding and improving LLMs' creative capabilities, particularly in scientific domains.

Education

- 2023 – Present 📌 **Ph.D. Computer Science.** EPFL, Switzerland.
Research on computational creativity.
- 2021 – 2023 📌 **M.Sc. Data Science.** EPFL, Switzerland.
Research on commonsense and causal reasoning.
- 2012 – 2016 📌 **B.Sc. Computer Science, With Distinction.** University of Waterloo, Canada.

Experience

Research

- Jul – Present 📌 **Student Researcher.** Google DeepMind. *London, UK.*
Research on LLMs for scientific discovery.
- Apr – Jun 2026 📌 **Research Intern.** Microsoft. *Cambridge, UK.*
Research on LLMs for scientific discovery.
- Sep 2023 – Feb 2025 📌 **Research Assistant.** Idiap Research Institute. *Martigny, Switzerland.*
- Fall 2022 📌 **Research Assistant.** AI Lab. EPFL. *Lausanne, Switzerland.*
Research on causal reasoning. Work published at ACL Findings.
- Jul - Sep 2022 📌 **Research Intern.** Sony Inc. *Tokyo, Japan.*
Developed a dialogue system that can imitate characters.

Engineering

- Jun 2019 – Aug 2021 📌 **Software/ML Engineer.** integrate AI. *Toronto, Canada.*
Designed and built ML tools to automate model training, prediction, and deployment.
- Sep 2017 – May 2019 📌 **Co-founder/CTO.** Destin AI. *Toronto, Canada.*
Designed and developed a chatbot and marketplace platform. Participation in startup incubators Next AI and DMZ.
- Sep 2017 – Jun 2018 📌 **Software Engineer.** Bluecat Networks. *Toronto, Canada.*
- Jun 2016 – Aug 2017 📌 **Software Engineer.** Cisco Systems. *Ottawa, Canada.*
- Summer 2015 📌 **Software Engineer Intern.** Freescale Semiconductors. *Ottawa, Canada.*
- Summer 2014 📌 **Software Engineer Intern.** TD Bank Securities. *Toronto, Canada.*

Selected Research Publications

Preprint

- 1 📌 **M. Ismayilzada**, D. Paul, A. Bosselut, and L. van der Plas, “Creativity in ai: progresses and challenges”, (2024).

Conference Proceedings

- 1 **M. Ismayilzada**, R. Cuomao, D. Yurshevich, A. Sotnikova, L. van der Plas, and A. Bosselut, “Cresowlve: benchmarking creative problem-solving over real-world knowledge”, in Proceedings of colm (2026).
- 2 **M. Ismayilzada**, S. A. Luchini, A. Gokce, B. AlKhamissi, A. Bosselut, A. L. Jr., L. van der Plas, and R. E. Beaty, “Large language models align with the human brain during creative thinking”, in Proceedings of colm (2026).
- 3 **M. Ismayilzada**, A. L. Jr., S. A. Luchini, R. Patel, A. Bosselut, L. van der Plas, and R. Beaty, “Creative preference optimization”, in Findings of the emnlp (2025).
- 4 **M. Ismayilzada**, C. Stevenson, and L. van der Plas, “Evaluating creative short story generation in humans and large language models”, in Proceedings of the iccc (2025).
- 5 **M. Ismayilzada**, D. Circi, J. Sälevä, H. Sirin, A. Köksal, B. Dhingra, A. Bosselut, D. Ataman, and L. V. D. Plas, “Evaluating morphological compositional generalization in large language models”, in Proceedings of the naacl (2025).
- 6 A. Hernández-Cano, ..., **M. Ismayilzada**, ..., and I. Schlag, “Apertus: democratizing open and compliant llms for global language environments”, in Proceedings of acl (2026).
- 7 **M. Ismayilzada**, D. Paul, S. Montariol, M. Geva, and A. Bosselut, “CRoW: benchmarking commonsense reasoning in real-world tasks”, in Proceedings of the emnlp (2023).
- 8 D. Paul, **M. Ismayilzada**, M. Peyrard, B. Borges, A. Bosselut, R. West, and B. Faltings, “REFINER: reasoning feedback on intermediate representations”, in Proceedings of the eacl (2024).

Awards

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| 2026 | ■ Outstanding Reviewer. IJCNLP AACL. |
| 2025 | ■ Swiss AI Initiative PhD Fellowship. Awarded for major contributions to the development of Apertus models. Swiss AI Initiative. |
| 2012-2016 | ■ Full State Scholarship. Full funding for undergraduate studies at the University of Waterloo. Government of Azerbaijan. |
| 2012 | ■ Certificate of Distinction. Euclid Mathematics Contest. University of Waterloo. |
| 2010 | ■ Presidential Scholarship. Awarded to top students entering university studies. Government of Azerbaijan. |

Teaching & Service

Teaching

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| Spring 2023-2025 | ■ Teaching Assistant. Modern NLP. EPFL. |
| Fall 2022, 2025 | ■ Teaching Assistant. Applied Data Analysis. EPFL. |
| Fall 2024 | ■ Teaching Assistant. Distributed Information Systems. EPFL. |

Service

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| 2024-Present | ■ Reviewer. ICML Human-AI Creativity Workshop, COLM, ACL ARR, SEM, EACL Student Research Workshop. |
| 2024 | ■ Volunteer. Perspectives on AI Symposiums, Idiap Research Institute. |